CAPITAL'S SCARS

Prominent terror attacks in Delhi since 1996. The Red Fort and its immediate surroundings have been targeted three times previously



GETTY IMAGES

Nov. 10, 2025
13 killed, over 20 injured as explosives-laden car explodes in front of Red Fort

Sept. 7, 2011
12 killed and 91 injured in a powerful blast at the Delhi High Court

Sept. 27, 2008
Three killed, 21 others injured in a blast at the Mehrauli flower market

The Delhi blast shook India's security establishment, as it signalled a new, dangerous turn that reopened a terror paradigm: terror attacks by educated professionals targeting India's big cities and planning major strikes similar to 26/11 in Mumbai in 2008. Says Shesh Paul Vaid, a former director general of J&K Police, "Umar became a suicide bomber even after qualifying as a doctor—the most sought-after profession in the Valley—and he was assisted in this act by other doctors. If you are ready to kill your own countrymen, imagine the kind of radicalisation that is taking place. This is a big challenge, and our security establishment needs to work on this front."

Especially as it was the first major terror attack in the capital in 14 years, the last one being in 2011 when a powerful explosion outside the Delhi High Court killed 12 and injured 91. The only other major terror attack outside of J&K in the following years was the twin blasts in Hyderabad in February 2013 that killed at least 16 and injured over 150 others. Then came the storming of the Pathankot air base in January 2016, but its target was military personnel, not civilians. Executed by the Pakistani terror outfit Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM), the Pathankot attack was carried out a month after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's surprise visit to Pakistan in December 2015.

Unlike before, Indian investigating agencies this time were circumspect about making their findings public, opting instead for a quiet investigation to identify the possible masterminds and perpetrators of the operation. Preliminary investigations did suggest a JeM hand, as its bases were the prime target of India's Operation Sindoor, launched after a terror attack in Pahalgam on April 22 this year killed 26 civilians. As part of the operation, the Indian armed forces bombed the JeM headquarters at Markaz Subhanallah in Bahawalpur, killing 10 members of chief Masood Azhar's family, including his elder sister Hawa Bibi. Four JeM terror training camps—Markaz Bilal, Markaz Abbas, Mahmona Joya and Sargal—were attacked, too, killing several cadres.

IT IS THE FIRST MAJOR TERROR ATTACK IN DELHI IN 14 YEARS AND IT SIGNALS THE RISE OF WHITE-COLLAR TERROR THAT HAS SHAKEN INDIA'S SECURITY ESTABLISHMENT

Unravelling the Conspiracy

Months after Op Sindoor, intelligence agencies found JeM handlers using encrypted messaging apps like Telegram to issue calls to avenge the deaths of Masood's kin. A threatening poster campaign in Srinagar's Nowgam village on October 18 alerted the J&K Police that mischief was afoot. Sustained efforts by the investigating team, led by SSP Sundeep Chakravarty (interestingly a qualified doctor himself who gave it up to join the police force), unravelled a network of doctors who wanted to execute deadly terror attacks across India, seemingly to avenge the JeM's losses in Op Sindoor.

After the posters came up, Chakravarty and his team did a rigorous scan of the CCTV footage to narrow down on three youths pasting them—Arif Nisar Dar alias Sahil, Yasir-ul-Ashraf and Maqsood Ahmed Dar, all Nowgam residents with a history of stone-pelting. Their arrest and interrogation revealed that their instruction had come from a cleric, Maulvi Irfan Ahmad Wagay, from Shopian in south Kashmir who served as the imam at a mosque in Nowgam in outer Srinagar. Irfan allegedly had a history of supplying weapons to terrorists, sending Kashmiri youth to Pakistan for training and inciting stone-pelting against the armed forces.

That past history established Irfan's involvement in peddling terrorist narratives among local youth. After the police nabbed him, a chain of confessions followed, beginning with his naming Adeel Majeed Rather, a doctor from Qazigund in south Kashmir who was working at the Famous Medical Super Specialty Hospital in Saharanpur, Uttar Pradesh, as